



DUJIANGYAN CHINA

Peanut Chicken in Dujiangyan

Gong bao ji ding is one of the most instantly recognizable Chinese dishes, served up as “spicy chicken with peanuts” in restaurants around the world. History links it to Dujiangyan, a small Sichuanese town just north of the provincial capital, Chengdu, and also to an ancient engineering project that long ago turned this region into one of China’s prime agricultural areas.



Gong bao (sometimes *kung po*) chicken is named after Ding Baozhen, the Governor of Sichuan in the 1880s (“Gong Bao” was his official title), whose household is said by some to

have invented this dish. Others claim that it is, in fact, an old recipe from neighboring Guizhou province, where Ding Baozhen was born, or that it was served up to him at a banquet by an obsequious subordinate looking for favors. It doesn’t really matter which story is true: this stir-fried assemblage of juicy chicken cubes, crunchy peanuts, chopped dried chili peppers, and aromatic Sichuan peppercorns (called *huajiao*, or “flower pepper” in Chinese), all held together by a malty-sour sauce, is deliciously addictive.

The combination of peppers and *huajiao* is distinctly Sichuanese, though *gong bao* chicken isn’t actually a hot dish by local standards. Some Sichuanese food is so fiery that even hardened locals glow crimson when eating it; to watch diners at a back-street night market tucking into innocuously named “boiled beef slices” or a communal, pepper-rich hotpot is to wince in sympathy. After a while, though,

this eye-watering diet becomes a necessity, and the Sichuanese justify their pepper cravings on health grounds, claiming that eating them warms you up in winter and helps you perspire during the summer, ultimately cooling you down.

Ding Baozhen is also famous for restoring Sichuan’s agricultural self-sufficiency. Dujiangyan sits where the farmland plains of eastern Sichuan meet the abrupt “foothills” – in reality, steep-sided mountains – of the Tibetan Plateau. Watercourses tumble off these hillsides into the notoriously capricious Min River, which used to cause havoc by alternately drying out or flooding the plains. In 256 BC the Han dynasty governor Li Bing designed a simple-looking collection of dams, dikes, and spillways to channel the river into an irrigation system. Ding Baozhen restored his work, and today’s vast waterways offer spectacular views over the channels and dams to the mountains and forests beyond. In taming the waters, Li Bing created an area of rich agricultural land, thereby granting the people a livelihood, and his efforts are commemorated in the temples of Erwang Miao and Fulong Guan – “Dragon-Taming Hall.”



Above Erwang Miao, the Two Kings Temple, is a tribute to Li Bing and his son, who first irrigated the plains during China’s Warring States period, 2,200 years ago

Sichuan Pepper

The characteristic Sichuanese taste is *mala*, literally “hot and numb,” created by combining the spicy heat of chili peppers with the aromatic tingle of Sichuan pepper. Also known as prickly ash, these peppercorn-sized fruits grow on ferociously thorny bushes in western Sichuan – market vendors often hold up scratched hands to prove how fresh their wares are. They contain a volatile oil that creates a weird pins-and-needles sensation in the mouth when eaten. The dried peppercorns are either cooked whole in a dish, as in *gong bao* chicken (be warned, it’s a bit of a shock when you bite into one) or ground to a powder and sprinkled over everything at the end. Sadly, the oil’s numbing effect doesn’t age well and peppercorns bought overseas rarely retain enough volatile oil to surprise an unwary diner.

A Day in Dujiangyan

Dujiangyan town itself is a functional transportation hub, so once you’ve arrived here from Chengdu, there’s no reason to put off heading straight for the riverside parkland surrounding the ancient irrigation works.

MORNING Head for **Lidui Park** and admire the main channel from venerable **Fulong Hall**, then catch a cable car over the Min River or cross more adventurously via the narrow **Anlan** suspension bridge. Either way you’ll reach **Erwang Miao**, the Two Kings Temple. Seek out the painted bust of Ding Baozhen in an alcove here, then walk through woodland back to town along the flagstoned **Songmao Path**, one of the ancient “tea roads” between Sichuan and Tibet.

AFTERNOON After lunch at one of the many riverside restaurants, head 15 miles (25 km) west to **Qingcheng Mountain**, a small but sacred Taoist peak. Climb the steep flights of steps through thick forest, pausing along the way to admire some small but beautiful temples and shrines.

EVENING Return to **Chengdu** for an evening stroll around the old streets surrounding Kuan Xiangzi, followed by a performance of traditional Sichuan opera.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Dujiangyan is 20 miles (30 km) north of Shuangliu **international airport** in Chengdu. A **train** service also runs from Chengdu’s north train station.

WHERE TO STAY

Dujiangyan is short on foreigner-friendly hotels, so it’s best to stay in Chengdu.

Sim’s (inexpensive) is centrally located and offers very friendly, helpful service. www.gogosc.com

The Holiday Inn Express (moderate) is business-oriented and very used to dealing with foreigners. www.holidayinnexpress.com.cn

The Jinjiang Hotel (expensive) is a Chinese-style luxury hotel downtown. www.jjhotel.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

194 Qintai Road, Chengdu; or check the listings magazine *GoChengdu*: www.gochengdoo.com